Hypertrophy & Strength Protocol

DUAL ADAPTATION METHOD



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Contents

An evidence-based 8-week system for building muscle and strength

Why Most Trainees Plateau, and How to Fix It . . . 3
- The Problem with Random Training . . . 3
- The Dual Adaptation Method in One Page . . . 3
- What the Science Says . . . 4
- Who This Is For . . . 4

Chapter 1: The Two Engines of Progress . . . 5
- Two Goals, One System . . . 5
- Why Sequence Them? . . . 6
- Six Rules of the Method . . . 6

Chapter 2: The Build Block . . . 7
- Volume: The Muscle Budget . . . 7
- The Week 1 to 4 Template . . . 8
- Progression Rules . . . 9

Chapter 3: The Express Block . . . 11
- Turning Muscle into Strength . . . 11
- Top Sets and Back-Off Sets . . . 11
- The Week 5 to 7 Template . . . 12

Chapter 4: The Effort Ladder . . . 13
- RPE and Reps in Reserve . . . 13
- Calibrating Your Effort . . . 13

Chapter 5: The Recovery Floor . . . 15
- Sleep: The Most Underrated Variable . . . 15
- The Recovery Floor Checklist . . . 15
- Reading Your Fatigue . . . 16

Chapter 6: The Plateau Decoder . . . 17
- Step 1: Confirm It Is a Plateau . . . 17
- Step 2: Find the Category . . . 17
- Step 3: Apply One Change at a Time . . . 18

Chapter 7: Fuelling the System . . . 19
- Protein . . . 19
- Calories . . . 19
- Supplements: Worth It or Not? . . . 20

Chapter 8: Run the Next Cycle . . . 21
- A Year of Cycles . . . 21
- Assessing Between Cycles . . . 21
- Adapting the Next Cycle . . . 22

Quick-Reference Systems & Terminology . . . 23
- The 8-Week Dual Adaptation Map . . . 23
- Glossary . . . 24
- Training Log Template . . . 25
- References . . . 25

INTRODUCTION

Why Most Trainees Plateau, and How to Fix It

A simple two-phase system that builds muscle first, then turns it into strength.

Most people who train consistently still plateau. Not because they lack effort, but because they are missing a system. This guide is that system.

The Problem with Random Training

Walk into any gym and you will find two kinds of trainees. The first group trains hard: they sweat, they push, they rarely skip a session. The second group trains with structure: they know why every set exists, how it connects to next week, and which signals tell them to push harder or pull back.

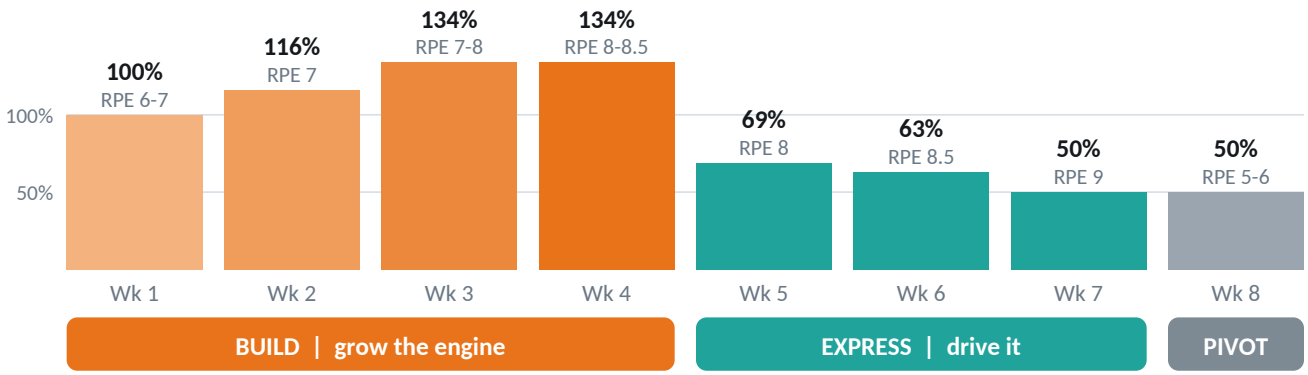
The first group usually stalls within a year. The second keeps progressing for years. Genetics matter, but the gap between these groups is mostly structure: planned progression, tracked effort and managed fatigue.

The Dual Adaptation Method in One Page

The method splits one 8-week cycle into two purposeful phases and a short reset. The **Build Block** grows muscle and expands your work capacity. The **Express Block** converts that new tissue into measurable strength. The **Pivot Week** clears accumulated fatigue so you can see (and bank) the gains. Then you start the next cycle from a higher baseline.

Weeks	Phase	RPE target	Primary focus	Volume
1-4	Build	6 to 8.5	Muscle size, work capacity, technique	Rising: 100% to 134%
5-7	Express	8 to 9	Heavy lifting, neural skill, strength	Falling: 69% to 50%
8	Pivot	5 to 6	Fatigue clearance, recovery	~50%

Weekly hard sets (% of Week 1 = 70 sets) and target RPE



What the Science Says

Training goals respond to different dials. Meta-analyses show that muscle growth is driven largely by hard sets performed close to failure, with a clear dose-response relationship between weekly sets and hypertrophy (Schoenfeld et al., 2017a). Muscle can grow across a wide range of loads when sets are taken near failure, but heavier loading produces larger gains in maximal strength (Schoenfeld et al., 2017b). That is why the Build Block leans on volume and moderate loads, and the Express Block leans on heavy, specific loading.

Fatigue hides fitness. The fitness-fatigue model describes performance as the balance between the positive adaptations from training and the fatigue it causes (Chiu and Barnes, 2003). Fitness can be present but masked until fatigue clears, which is why the cycle ends with a planned Pivot Week.

Muscle is easier to keep than to build. Research on training dose shows that lifters can maintain muscle size with far less volume than it took to build it (Bickel et al., 2011). That is what allows the Express Block to cut volume and still protect your gains.

EVIDENCE CHECK

Be honest about what "periodization" proves

Reviews of the literature find that periodized programs tend to produce somewhat larger strength gains than non-periodized ones (Williams et al., 2017), but no single periodization model has been proven superior for muscle growth when training volume is equal. Training both qualities at once also works, especially for newer lifters. The value of this method is not magic sequencing. It is a clear structure that organizes volume, intensity, effort and recovery so you actually progress and can tell why.

Who This Is For

- Lifters with at least 3 to 6 months of consistent training who are comfortable with the squat, bench press, deadlift and overhead press.
- People who can train 4 days per week for 8 weeks (a 3-day option is in Chapter 8).
- Anyone stuck on the same weights, or who has been "training hard" without a plan.

SAFETY NOTE

Before you start

This guide is educational and is not medical advice. Check with a doctor or qualified sports medicine professional before starting if you have a heart condition, high blood pressure, are pregnant, are recovering from injury, or have any condition that could be affected by heavy lifting. Learn the main lifts with qualified coaching, use safety arms or a spotter, and stop any set for sharp pain.

CHAPTER 1

The Two Engines of Progress

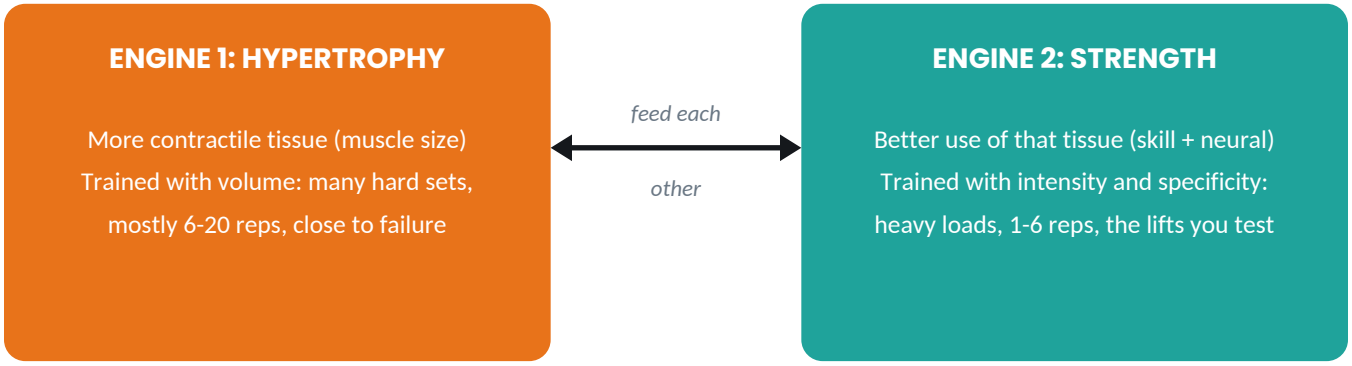
Muscle and strength are related, but they are not the same thing.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- → Hypertrophy versus strength
- → Why one system can train both
- → The rules this program follows

Two Goals, One System

Hypertrophy is the growth of muscle tissue. **Strength** is your ability to produce force in a specific movement, which depends on how much muscle you have *and* how well your nervous system recruits, coordinates and applies it. Both matter, and they respond to different emphasis.



Think of it as an engine analogy. Hypertrophy training grows the engine: it increases the cross-sectional area of muscle fibers, strengthens connective tissue, and builds the work capacity to handle hard sets. Strength training teaches you to drive that engine: it improves motor unit recruitment, coordination between muscles, and technique under heavy loads.

MYTH VS. REALITY

"You have to choose between size and strength."

You do not. Bigger muscles have a higher force ceiling, which is why muscle size and strength are strongly related. But strength is also a skill: two lifters with the same muscle can lift very different weights if one has practiced the lift heavily. Training for size alone leaves strength on the table, and training heavy alone leaves muscle growth on the table.

Why Sequence Them?

Doing both at once is possible, but it spreads your effort thin. Sequencing lets each block have a single job, a clear measure of success and a different set of rules. In practice, the benefits are:

1. **Focus.** In the Build Block every decision serves volume and quality reps. In the Express Block every decision serves heavy, crisp lifting.
2. **Carryover.** More muscle raises your potential, then three weeks of heavy practice cashes it in.
3. **Managed fatigue.** High-volume training builds fatigue; heavy training needs you fresh. Reducing volume as intensity rises respects that.

Six Rules of the Method

Rule	What it means in practice
1. Progress is planned	Every session has sets, reps and an RPE target. Nothing is "see how I feel".
2. Effort is calibrated	Most sets stop 1 to 3 reps before failure (Chapter 4).
3. Volume rises, then falls	Build adds sets over three weeks; Express cuts sets as loads get heavier.
4. Log everything	You cannot diagnose what you did not record (Chapter 6).
5. Recovery has a floor	Sleep, protein and food intake have minimums you do not skip (Chapter 5).
6. Cycles compound	Each 8-week cycle starts from the new baseline (Chapter 8).

KEY TAKEAWAY

Hypertrophy grows the engine. Strength training teaches you to drive it. Run them in sequence, protect recovery, and track everything.

CHAPTER 2

The Build Block

Four weeks of deliberate accumulation. The goal is not to go heavy; it is to build muscle and volume tolerance.

IN THIS CHAPTER

→ Volume: the muscle budget
→ The Week 1 to 4 template
→ Progression rules

Volume: The Muscle Budget

Each muscle group has a weekly "budget" of productive hard sets. Too little and adaptation is minimal. Too much and fatigue accumulates faster than you can recover. A **hard set** here means a set taken within roughly 0 to 3 reps of failure (RPE 7 to 10). Warm-up sets do not count.

Muscle group	Minimum effective	Productive range	This program, Wk 1	This program, Wk 4
Chest	6 sets	10-18 sets	8	11
Back	8 sets	12-20 sets	12	15
Quads	6 sets	10-16 sets	10	14
Hamstrings	4 sets	6-12 sets	8	10
Glutes	4 sets	6-14 sets	5	6
Shoulders	6 sets	8-16 sets	9	12
Biceps	4 sets	6-14 sets	4	6
Triceps	4 sets	6-14 sets	4	6
Calves	6 sets	8-14 sets	6	8

Weekly direct hard sets. Hamstring, glute, biceps and triceps volume is helped by indirect work from squats, rows and presses, so their direct sets can sit lower. Treat these as starting guidelines; individual tolerance varies.

EVIDENCE CHECK

Where the numbers come from

A dose-response meta-analysis found that higher weekly volume per muscle produced greater hypertrophy, with roughly 10 or more weekly sets outperforming fewer (Schoenfeld et al., 2017a). Returns diminish at high volumes and individual responses vary, so this program starts low and adds sets only as you earn them.

Warning signs you have too much

- Performance falls for 2 or more sessions in a row at the same effort
- Joint or tendon pain that builds across the week (elbows, knees, shoulders)
- Sleep disruption, low mood or loss of motivation to train
- Soreness that is still limiting you after 48 to 72 hours

The Week 1 to 4 Template

Four sessions per week on an upper/lower split: Monday, Tuesday, Thursday, Friday. Each muscle is trained twice weekly, with at least a day between sessions for the same area. Sessions take roughly 60 to 80 minutes.

Upper A (Monday)			
Exercise	**Primary muscle**	**Sets (Wk 1 to 4)**	**Reps**
Barbell bench press	Chest	3 to 4	6-8
Chest-supported row	Back	3 to 4	8-10
Incline dumbbell press	Chest	2 to 3	8-12
Lat pulldown	Back	3 to 4	8-12
Lateral raise	Shoulders	3 to 4	12-20
Cable triceps pushdown	Triceps	2 to 3	10-15
Dumbbell curl	Biceps	2 to 3	10-15

Lower A (Tuesday)			
Exercise	**Primary muscle**	**Sets (Wk 1 to 4)**	**Reps**
Back squat	Quads	3 to 4	5-8
Romanian deadlift	Hamstrings	3	8-10
Leg press	Quads	2 to 3	10-15
Lying leg curl	Hamstrings	3 to 4	10-15
Standing calf raise	Calves	3 to 4	10-15
Cable crunch	Abs	2 to 3	10-15

Upper B (Thursday)			
Exercise	**Primary muscle**	**Sets (Wk 1 to 4)**	**Reps**
Overhead press	Shoulders	3 to 4	6-10
Weighted pull-up (or assisted)	Back	3 to 4	6-10
Dumbbell bench press	Chest	3 to 4	8-12
Seated cable row	Back	3	10-12
Rear-delt fly or face pull	Shoulders	3 to 4	12-20
Overhead triceps extension	Triceps	2 to 3	10-15
Incline dumbbell curl	Biceps	2 to 3	10-15

Lower B (Friday)			
Exercise	**Primary muscle**	**Sets (Wk 1 to 4)**	**Reps**
Trap-bar or conventional deadlift	Glutes	2 to 3	4-6
Hack squat or front squat	Quads	3 to 4	8-10
Walking lunge or split squat	Quads	2 to 3	10-12 / leg
Seated leg curl	Hamstrings	2 to 3	10-15
Hip thrust	Glutes	3	8-12
Seated calf raise	Calves	3 to 4	12-20
Hanging leg raise	Abs	2 to 3	10-15

Total hard sets per week: Week 1 = 70, Week 2 = 81, Week 3 = 94, Week 4 = 94.

Progression Rules

Week	Sets	Effort (RPE)	Goal
1	Starting sets	6-7 (3-4 reps in reserve)	Find working loads, practice technique, calibrate RPE
2	Add 1 set to exercises that go 2 to 3	7 (3 in reserve)	Build rhythm; beat Week 1 reps or load
3	Add 1 set to exercises that go 3 to 4	7.5-8 (2 in reserve)	Full planned sets reached
4	Same sets as Week 3	8-8.5 (1-2 in reserve)	Peak volume held; highest effort of the block

Double progression

For every exercise, pick a load that lets you reach the bottom of the rep range at the target RPE. When you hit the **top** of the range on all sets at that RPE, increase the load by about 2.5 to 5% (1 to 2.5 kg on small lifts) and start the range again. Add reps before adding weight.

TRY THIS

Session checklist

- Warm up with 2 to 4 progressively heavier ramp-up sets on the first exercise
- Rest 2 to 3 minutes between heavy compound sets, 1 to 2 minutes on isolation work
- Log load, reps and RPE for every working set
- Stop the set when form breaks, even if you could do more reps

KEY TAKEAWAY

Volume is a budget, not a goal. Start at the low end, add sets only when performance and recovery allow, and keep most sets 1 to 3 reps from failure.

CHAPTER 3

The Express Block

You've built the engine. Now you learn to drive it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- → How heavy training builds strength
- → The Week 5 to 7 template
- → Setting your top sets

Turning Muscle into Strength

Heavier loads recruit high-threshold motor units immediately, and repeated practice with heavy weights improves coordination, bracing and technique. Strength gains are also **specific**: you get better at the lifts and rep ranges you practice. Over three weeks of heavy, low-rep work on the main lifts, you learn to express the muscle you built.

EVIDENCE CHECK

Why three weeks and lower volume?

Heavy sets are very fatiguing, and the fitness-fatigue model predicts that performance peaks when fatigue is reduced (Chiu and Barnes, 2003). Because muscle can be maintained with much less volume than it takes to build (Bickel et al., 2011), cutting sets during Weeks 5 to 7 costs little muscle and frees recovery capacity for heavy loads.

Top Sets and Back-Off Sets

Work up to a **top set** at the prescribed reps and RPE, then drop the load by about 5 to 8% for **back-off sets** at the same reps. Back-offs add volume at a manageable cost.

Week	Top set	Back-offs (squat, bench, press)	Back-offs (deadlift)
5	1 x 5 @ RPE 8	3 x 5, about 6% lighter	2 x 5, about 6% lighter
6	1 x 4 @ RPE 8.5	3 x 4, about 6% lighter	2 x 4, about 6% lighter
7	1 x 3 @ RPE 9	2 x 3, about 6% lighter	1 x 3, about 6% lighter

SAFETY NOTE

Keep heavy sets safe

RPE 9 means one rep left in reserve, not a grind to failure. Use safety arms or a spotter on squat and bench, pull the deadlift from a stable setup, and cut the set short if technique breaks down. If a top set is slower or sloppier than expected, take a lighter load.

The Week 5 to 7 Template

Same four days. Each session has one **main lift** (top set plus back-offs), a **secondary lift** and two accessories.

Day 1 (Monday): Squat			
Exercise	**Role**	**Sets (Wk 5 / 6 / 7)**	**Scheme**
Back squat	Main	4 / 4 / 3	Top set + back-off sets
Romanian deadlift	Secondary	3 / 3 / 2	6-8 reps @ RPE 7
Chest-supported row	Accessory	3 / 3 / 2	8-10 reps @ RPE 7-8
Lying leg curl	Accessory	3 / 2 / 2	10-12 reps @ RPE 8

Day 2 (Tuesday): Bench			
Exercise	**Role**	**Sets (Wk 5 / 6 / 7)**	**Scheme**
Barbell bench press	Main	4 / 4 / 3	Top set + back-off sets
Weighted pull-up (or assisted)	Secondary	3 / 3 / 2	5-8 reps @ RPE 7-8
Lateral raise	Accessory	3 / 2 / 2	12-15 reps @ RPE 8
Cable triceps pushdown	Accessory	2 / 2 / 2	10-12 reps @ RPE 8

Day 4 (Thursday): Deadlift			
Exercise	**Role**	**Sets (Wk 5 / 6 / 7)**	**Scheme**
Trap-bar or conventional deadlift	Main	3 / 3 / 2	Top set + back-off sets
Front squat or leg press	Secondary	3 / 3 / 2	6-8 reps @ RPE 7
Standing calf raise	Accessory	3 / 2 / 2	8-12 reps @ RPE 8
Hanging leg raise	Accessory	2 / 2 / 2	8-12 reps @ RPE 8

Day 5 (Friday): Overhead press			
Exercise	**Role**	**Sets (Wk 5 / 6 / 7)**	**Scheme**
Overhead press	Main	4 / 4 / 3	Top set + back-off sets
Dumbbell bench press	Secondary	3 / 3 / 2	6-8 reps @ RPE 7
Seated cable row	Accessory	3 / 2 / 2	8-10 reps @ RPE 7-8
Dumbbell curl	Accessory	2 / 2 / 2	8-12 reps @ RPE 8

Total hard sets per week: Week 5 = 48, Week 6 = 44, Week 7 = 35.

KEY TAKEAWAY

The Express Block is about quality: heavy, crisp, repeatable reps on the main lifts, with volume dropping each week so you stay fresh.

CHAPTER 4

The Effort Ladder

Effort should build across the block, not live at maximum from day one.

IN THIS CHAPTER

→ The RPE scale and reps in reserve
→ Calibrating your effort
→ Converting reps to loads

RPE and Reps in Reserve

RPE (rating of perceived exertion) on a 1 to 10 scale is tied to how many reps you have left in the tank. In resistance training, RPE 10 means you could not do another rep with acceptable form; RPE 9 means one more rep was possible; and so on (Zourdos et al., 2016). The count of remaining reps is called **reps in reserve (RIR)**.

RPE	Reps in reserve	What it feels like	Where you use it
10	0	Absolute maximum; no more reps with good form	Rarely; only on isolation exercises, never heavy compounds
9	1	Very hard; maybe one more rep	Express top sets (Week 7)
8	2	Hard; two more reps possible	Late Build weeks, Express Weeks 5 to 6
7	3	Challenging but smooth; bar speed still good	Build Weeks 2 to 3, secondary lifts
6	4	Moderate work; clearly stopped early	Build Week 1, Pivot Week
5	5+	Light; a warm-up or recovery set	Pivot Week, ramp-up sets

Calibrating Your Effort

Learning to judge effort accurately is one of the most valuable skills a trainee can build. Research shows that people tend to misjudge how many reps they have left, particularly on higher-rep sets and when far from failure, and that accuracy improves with practice (Halperin et al., 2022; Helms et al., 2016). You cannot train harder by feel until your feel is accurate.

TRY THIS

Three calibration drills

- **Predict, then test.** After a set, write down how many reps you thought were left. On an isolation exercise, finish with one extra set to failure to check.
- **Film your sets.** Bar speed slows noticeably in the last reps, and video shows you when you were closer to failure than you felt.
- **Use rep-range anchors.** If a load that normally gives you 8 reps takes you for 6, your RPE call was off by 2.

Reps and approximate percentages of your one-rep max

Use this table to pick starting loads. It assumes the set is taken to failure; if you leave reps in reserve, add them to the reps you did. For example, 5 reps at RPE 8 (2 in reserve) is treated like a 7-rep max, around 80%.

Reps to failure	1	2	3	4	5	6	8	10	12
Approx. % of 1RM	100	95	93	90	87	85	80	75	70

Approximate values for common barbell lifts. Individuals vary, and lifts with a long range of motion or a high technical demand deviate more.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Effort should build across the block. Calibrate with notes, video and honest tracking; the goal is not training harder, but training more accurately.

CHAPTER 5

The Recovery Floor

Training is the stimulus. Recovery is where adaptation happens.

IN THIS CHAPTER

→ Sleep: the biggest lever
→ The minimum recovery standards
→ Reading your fatigue

Without a minimum recovery floor, no program, however well designed, produces the results it should. The floor is not about perfection. It is a short list of non-negotiables that keep the stimulus from outrunning your ability to adapt.

Sleep: The Most Underrated Variable

Sleep is the most important recovery variable and the most underestimated. Reviews of the research (Dattilo et al., 2011) propose that sleep restriction shifts the hormonal environment against muscle repair, and a controlled trial of total sleep deprivation found reduced muscle protein synthesis and a less favorable hormone profile (Lamon et al., 2021). Sleep also affects mood, motivation, appetite and injury risk, all of which touch your training indirectly.

EVIDENCE CHECK

What is known and what is not

The link between short sleep and poorer training outcomes is consistent, but much of the direct evidence on muscle comes from short, acute studies and hypotheses. Treat 7 or more hours as a practical target, not a magic number, and prioritize consistency.

The Recovery Floor Checklist

Standard	Minimum	Why it matters
Sleep	7+ hours on most nights	Training quality, appetite, recovery
Protein	1.6 to 2.2 g per kg daily	Raw material for repair (Chapter 7)
Energy intake	At or above maintenance	Hard training on too little food stalls
Spacing	~48 hours between same-muscle sessions	Lets soreness and tissue stress resolve
Rest days	2+ full rest or easy days weekly	Nervous system and joints recover
Stress	Some daily downtime; walks count	High life stress lowers recovery
Pain	No sharp or worsening joint pain	Soreness is normal; joint pain is a stop signal

Reading Your Fatigue

Fatigue is not the enemy; unmanaged fatigue is. Track a quick three-point check each morning for the build blocks, and let the pattern guide your decisions:

Signal	Green: train as planned	Red: reduce volume or load
Sleep last night	7+ hours, woke rested	Under 5 to 6 hours, repeated
Warm-up feel	Bar moves as expected	Weights feel unusually heavy
Motivation / mood	Looking forward to training	Dread, irritability, flat mood
Aches	Normal muscle soreness	Joint or tendon pain building

If two or more signals are red for several days, bring the Pivot Week forward or cut sets by 30 to 50% for 3 to 5 days before resuming.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Protect the floor: sleep, protein, food, rest and pain awareness. These minimums are what let the program produce its results.

CHAPTER 6

The Plateau Decoder

A plateau is not a sign you have hit your genetic ceiling. It is a diagnostic signal.

IN THIS CHAPTER

→ Confirming it is a real plateau
→ The five categories
→ A fix for each

Step 1: Confirm It Is a Plateau

Before changing anything, check your data. Have you logged consistent loads, reps and RPE for the past 3 to 4 weeks? If not, start there. Day-to-day performance varies with sleep, stress and food, so one bad session is noise.

TRY THIS

The plateau test

- No improvement in estimated one-rep max or rep performance at the same RPE for **2 to 3 weeks** on a lift (3 to 4 weeks if you are more advanced)
- Your RPE and set count were honest and consistent
- Sleep and food were roughly normal, not unusually disrupted

To estimate your one-rep max from any set, use the formula: **e1RM = weight x (1 + (reps + reps in reserve) / 30)**. For example, 100 kg for 5 reps at RPE 8 (2 in reserve) gives 100 x (1 + 7/30), or about 123 kg. Compare e1RM week to week, not single sessions.

Step 2: Find the Category

Most plateaus fall into one of five categories. Work through them in order, because the earlier ones are the most common and cheapest to fix.

#	Category	Typical signs	Fix
1	Not enough stimulus	Sets are far from failure; same loads and sets for many weeks; sessions feel easy	Raise effort to RPE 8 to 9 on working sets; add 1 to 2 sets per muscle; apply double progression
2	Too much fatigue	Performance dropping, achy joints, poor sleep, low motivation	Pull the Pivot Week forward; cut volume by 30 to 50% for a week; audit sleep and stress
3	Fueling gap	Body weight flat or falling; low energy; poor pumps and recovery	Add 200 to 300 kcal daily; check protein; eat carbs around training

#	Category	Typical signs	Fix
4	Stale programming or technique	Same exercises and rep ranges for 6+ weeks; form breaking down	Swap 30 to 40% of accessories; film main lifts; restore range of motion and tempo
5	Measurement or expectations	Inconsistent logging; short comparison windows; expecting novice-speed gains	Track a 4-week rolling e1RM and weekly body weight; compare like for like

Step 3: Apply One Change at a Time

Change one variable, give it 2 to 3 weeks, and record the result. Changing many things at once makes it impossible to know what worked. If progress returns, keep the change. If not, move to the next category.

EVIDENCE CHECK

Progress slows with experience

Rates of muscle and strength gain fall as you get more trained, so a plateau at an advanced level may be a real slowdown rather than an error. That is why the method rewards smaller, measured gains across multiple cycles over big jumps in one.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Confirm the plateau with data, find the category, change one thing, and re-measure. Most plateaus are solved by logging, effort calibration or recovery, not new exercises.

CHAPTER 7

Fuelling the System

Nutrition does not need to be complicated, but it does need to be consistent.

IN THIS CHAPTER

→ The three things that matter most
→ Protein and calorie targets
→ Supplements: what is worth it

Three things matter far more than everything else combined: **protein, total calories and showing up every day**. Get those right first. Everything else is fine-tuning.

Protein

Protein supplies the amino acids your body uses to repair and build muscle. Across studies of resistance training, gains in muscle mass from higher protein intake level off at about **1.6 g per kg of body weight per day** (Morton et al., 2018), and sports nutrition position stands support 1.4 to 2.0 g per kg for most trainees (Jager et al., 2017). A practical target is 1.6 to 2.2 g per kg per day, spread over 3 to 5 meals of 0.3 to 0.4 g per kg each.

Calories

Goal	Calories vs. maintenance	Expected pattern
Build muscle (lean gain)	About 5 to 10% above (roughly 200 to 300 kcal)	Slow weight gain, about 0.25 to 0.5% of body weight per week
Recomposition	At maintenance or 100 to 200 kcal below	Weight steady, waist flat or down, strength rising
Fat loss while keeping muscle	300 to 500 kcal below	Slow loss; keep protein high and lift heavy

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example: 80 kg lifter in a lean gain

- Maintenance estimate: about 2,700 kcal; target: 2,950 kcal (+250)
- Protein: 2.0 g/kg = 160 g (640 kcal)
- Fat: 0.9 g/kg = 72 g (648 kcal)
- Carbohydrate: remaining 1,662 kcal / 4 = about 415 g (5.2 g/kg), weighted around training

Supplements: Worth It or Not?

Supplement	Evidence	Practical take
Creatine monohydrate	Strong	3 to 5 g daily. One of the best-supported supplements for strength and lean mass (Kreider et al., 2017). Safe for healthy adults.
Whey protein	Strong (as food)	A convenient way to reach protein targets; not required if food covers your needs.
Caffeine	Moderate	3 to 6 mg per kg about 30 to 60 minutes before training can improve performance; avoid late in the day.
Most "muscle builders", BCAAs, boosters	Weak	Little added benefit if protein intake is adequate.

Whey protein: a quick decision guide

If this describes you...	Then...
Whole foods already deliver your protein target comfortably	You do not need whey.
You struggle to reach your target or want convenience	Whey concentrate is cost-effective for most people.
You are lactose-sensitive or cutting calories tightly	Whey isolate (lower in lactose, fat and carbs) is worth the extra cost.
You avoid dairy	Use a soy or pea-rice blend with a complete amino acid profile.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Hit protein daily, eat enough overall, take creatine if you like, and treat other supplements as optional extras.

CHAPTER 8

Run the Next Cycle

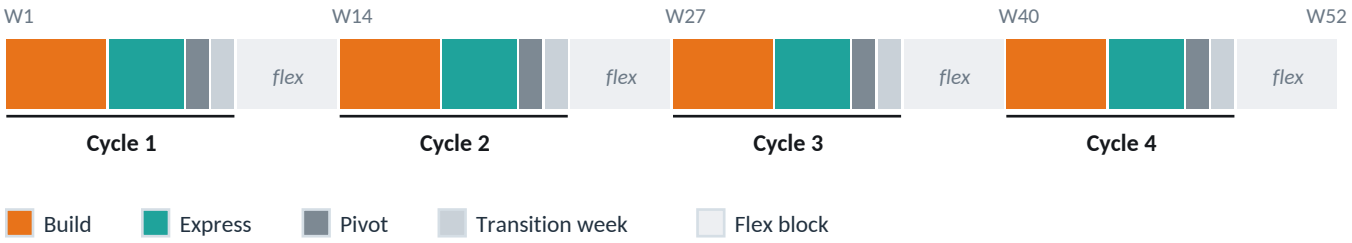
One cycle produces real results. Compounding cycles is where transformation lives.

IN THIS CHAPTER

→ A year of cycles
→ Assessing between cycles
→ Adapting the next cycle

A Year of Cycles

Three to four 8-week cycles per year, each followed by a short transition and a flexible block, gives you steady progress with time for life, holidays and specialization. A four-cycle year looks like this:



Over 52 weeks, four cycles contain **16 Build weeks**, **12 Express weeks** and **4 Pivot weeks**. The remaining weeks are four transition weeks and 16 flexible weeks for maintenance training, specialization (for example, extra arm or shoulder work) or planned breaks.

EVIDENCE CHECK

Why not run cycles back to back forever?

Continuous hard blocks can accumulate fatigue and leave no room to reflect. Brief transitions and lighter blocks keep the habit going while letting joints, motivation and recovery catch up.

Assessing Between Cycles

During the transition week (after the Pivot Week), take stock. Use light training, then test.

1. **Strength:** take a top set on each main lift (3 to 5 reps at RPE 9) and compute e1RM. Compare with the start of the cycle.
2. **Size:** record body weight (weekly average), waist, and progress photos in the same light, time and pose.
3. **Recovery:** review sleep, soreness and motivation across the cycle.

4. **Adherence:** count sessions completed out of 32.

Adapting the Next Cycle

What you found	Adjust the next cycle
Strength up, muscle up, recovery good	Start 1 to 2 sets higher per muscle; keep main lifts, rotate a few accessories.
Strength up, size flat	Add 2 to 4 hard sets to lagging muscles; raise Build RPE to 8 earlier; check calories.
Size up, strength flat	Extend Express to 4 weeks (shorten Build to 3); add main-lift specificity.
Both flat, low adherence or poor recovery	Reduce to 3 days per week, restore the recovery floor, then re-run the same cycle.
Persistent joint pain	Swap offending exercises, lower loads, and consider seeing a clinician.

A 3-day version

If you can only train three days per week, run a full-body layout: each session has a main lift, a secondary lift and 3 to 4 accessories covering upper and lower body. Use the same RPE and progression rules and keep total weekly hard sets per muscle in the productive range from Chapter 2, scaled down by about 20%.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Progress compounds. Run a cycle, test, adjust, and begin again from a higher baseline. The trainee who runs this system for a year builds a record of what works for their body.

APPENDIX

Quick-Reference Systems & Terminology

Everything you need on one page, plus a log to print.

The 8-Week Dual Adaptation Map

Week	Phase	Hard sets (all muscles)	RPE target	Key focus
1	Build	70	6-7	Calibrate loads; learn rhythm
2	Build	81	7	Add sets; beat Week 1
3	Build	94	7-8	Full sets reached; effort rising
4	Build	94	8-8.5	Peak volume held; highest Build effort
5	Express	48	8	Top set x5 @ RPE 8
6	Express	44	8.5	Top set x4 @ RPE 8.5
7	Express	35	9	Top set x3 @ RPE 9
8	Pivot	35	5-6	Fatigue clearance

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Hypertrophy	Growth in the size of muscle fibers; the increase in muscle mass.
Hard set	A set taken within about 0 to 3 reps of failure; warm-ups do not count.
RPE	Rating of perceived exertion (1 to 10) tied to reps left in reserve.
RIR	Reps in reserve: how many more reps you could have done.
1RM / e1RM	One-rep max, and an estimate of it from a submaximal set.
Top set / back-off set	The heaviest working set at the target RPE, and lighter sets after it.
Double progression	Raise reps within a range first, then add load and repeat.
Periodization	Planned variation of volume, intensity and exercises over time.
Pivot Week	The planned low-effort week that clears fatigue at the end of each cycle.
Fitness-fatigue model	Performance equals fitness gained minus fatigue accumulated.

Training Log Template

Photocopy or print this page. Record load x reps and RPE for each working set.

Exercise	Set 1	Set 2	Set 3	Set 4	RPE	Notes

Date	Session	Sleep (h)	Body weight	Energy 1-5

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This guide is intended for educational purposes. Consult a qualified sports medicine professional before beginning any new training program.